months has not been great. I appreciate that we've been plotting a path to this World Cup, and through to the Ashes next summer, but whatever decision is made I will not bear a grudge towards you.'

I had no interest in discovering the voting patterns, or whether, by making that assurance, I had inadvertently tipped the balance against me. When I took a call from Whitaker, asking if he could come to see me at home, it was obvious that the die had been cast. It was a big blow. I was back, deep in the bush.

There was only one person to blame, myself. I couldn't moan about being left out because I hadn't scored the runs, but it dented my pride and almost destroyed my spirit. To be brutally honest, for two or three days around Christmas I didn't really want to walk down the street. As ridiculous as it seems, I imagined strangers whispering, 'He's the bloke who's just got sacked.'

I rang Eoin Morgan on the day he was appointed as my successor with the one-day team, to offer any help I could. I wished him well and assured him there were no hard feelings. He'd been given a hospital pass in many ways, because at that point in our development we were behind the curve in a limited-overs game that was changing so radically, so quickly.

Instead of measured, quantifiable preparation over the life cycle of a World Cup, we were like a student doing crash-course revision, trying to respond to the new realities of the game in a fifteen-match programme. Predictably, a young team uncertain of its identity failed to qualify for the knock-out phase in Australia and New Zealand.

I had three months at home before a tour of the West Indies from mid-April. I had been worn down by the KP saga, with its blizzard of unflattering headlines. Even my default position, grinding my way out of trouble, seemed dispiritingly inadequate. I pride myself on self-reliance, but I needed Alice to retain my sanity.

So much had happened in such a short space of time. I just unloaded on Alice, and her support was unwavering. I tried to see things from her perspective, as we were both coming to terms with the joys and responsibilities of the birth of our daughter, Elsie. Alice couldn't score my runs, chair my team meetings, reply to my detractors. She had to endure my hurt at the relentless negativity. She was on the outside looking in, and I was on the inside, cut to the quick. I had to hunker down and wait for my reward, because it was me against the world.